bought at the ‘out-agents’ at Tiruchirappalli, Madurai, Kollam and Tirunelveli, apart from Tuticorin.[152]

Training

As the company made progress in steamer service and increased its freight business, it began to turn its attention to larger goals. Training of indigenous recruits in navigation was an article of faith for SSNCo. Despite its limited resources and the difficult circumstances in which it operated, the company did not lose sight of this objective. Unless the crew too was Indian, shipping could not be authentically Swadeshi. Presenting evidence, a decade later, to the Indian Mercantile Marine Committee, S.D. Krishna Aiyangar argued that training some apprentices should be a precondition for shipowners receiving state aid and added that those who resisted this idea ‘do not deserve sympathy’.[153] The brains behind SSNCo also believed that learning navigation was not complicated. An apprentice could soon be a second mate and then he could easily qualify as master mariner after two or three years.[154]

Towards this end, even in the first year of its operation, SSNCo admitted four apprentices.[155] None of them were graduates: one was an undergraduate while others were matriculates. Two were Bengalis, one of whom came from an engineering college in Calcutta. The other two were locals, of whom one was a Brahmin. Interestingly, for some time, he was ‘making a pretence of taking his food separate’ but soon ‘abandoned all scruples’.[156] Caste was an issue with seafaring being a taboo for many ‘upper’ castes. Given the small cohort of trainees, SSNCo probably managed the problem without too much friction.

The *South Indian Mail* confirms that SSNCo took the initiative to train five youths, drawn from various parts of India (two Bengalis, one Punjabi, ‘Madrasi’ and Ceylonese each) in the science of navigation. Commending them for valuing the dignity of manual labour, the Madurai-based English daily, noted that the Ceylonese apprentice had been made third officer of the *Gallia*. The police took an unhealthy interest in this trainee. Identifying